

The emergence of new lobbies and moneybags from mining, real estate and education in the electoral race promises to alter the face of state politics

■ By Stephen David

Kupendra Reddy looks like a nondescript trader from Bangalore's busy wholesalers' avenues of Chikpet and Balepet. But the first-time Congress candidate from Bommanahalli is one of the richest real estate tycoons to foray into the state's electoral scene. Canvassing for votes, he is promising the electorate good roads, adequate drinking water supply and proper infrastructure—a standard mantra that almost every other candidate is embracing as the state readies for the first leg of the three-phase polls, to be held on May 10, 16 and 22. Reddy, who lives in the posh HSR Layout area, is one of the many billionaires dotting the state's changing political landscape.

Forty-seven-year-old Reddy, who has declared that he and his family own property worth Rs 180.25 crore, out of which he himself owns Rs 131.23 crore, has been in the news ever since his house was raided by the Income Tax Department in July last year—not out of turn, considering that Reddy's savings alone amount to Rs 54.92



KUPENDRA REDDY CONGRESS

Rs 180.25 crore is the value of the property owned by him and his family. The real estate tycoon is contesting from Bommanahalli.

"Bangalore requires world-class infrastructure and that is what we want to deliver."



E. KRISHNAPPA JD(S)

Rs 44 crore is what the producer of the superhit Kannada movie *Mungaru Male* is worth. He is contesting the Yelahanka seat.

"In real life we know what is good for the people and we will achieve that, just like we did in reel life."

THE CASH CLOUT

crore. He hails from one of the many landed families who have earned their crores almost overnight thanks to the real estate boom. "My family owned hundreds of acres in the HSR Layout, but we gave it away to the Bangalore Development Authority," he says, with a philanthropic flourish. Reddy's family still owns six acres in the area, where an acre costs Rs 16 crore today.

Politicians like former BJP minister for industry Katta Subramaniam Naidu and D.K. Shivakumar of the Congress have raked in big bucks from the

business, but clearly, the scenario has changed now, with a dozen real estate tycoons getting into politics fulltime in Bangalore alone, with an eye on the 28 Assembly constituencies in the city. The wealthiest crorepati to be contesting the upcoming polls, G. Prasad Reddy, 55, who has a BJP ticket from BTM Layout, has assets worth Rs 313 crore. Schooled only till Class X, he struck gold in the realty business, and now owns a fleet of cars including BMWs and a Bentley. Navkesh Batra, a Bangalore-based legal eagle who has a large clien-

tele of real estate rajas, puts it succinctly: "When politicians can get into real estate, it is no surprise that real estate tycoons get into politics too."

While some tycoons secured candidature, others failed to do so because of caste and demographic configurations. The richest landlords in Bangalore, for example, are the Telugu Reddys, who have owned land in and around the city for years. Some of the biggest commercial and residential complexes, including the biggest mall, Forum, sit on land owned by the early Telugu immigrants